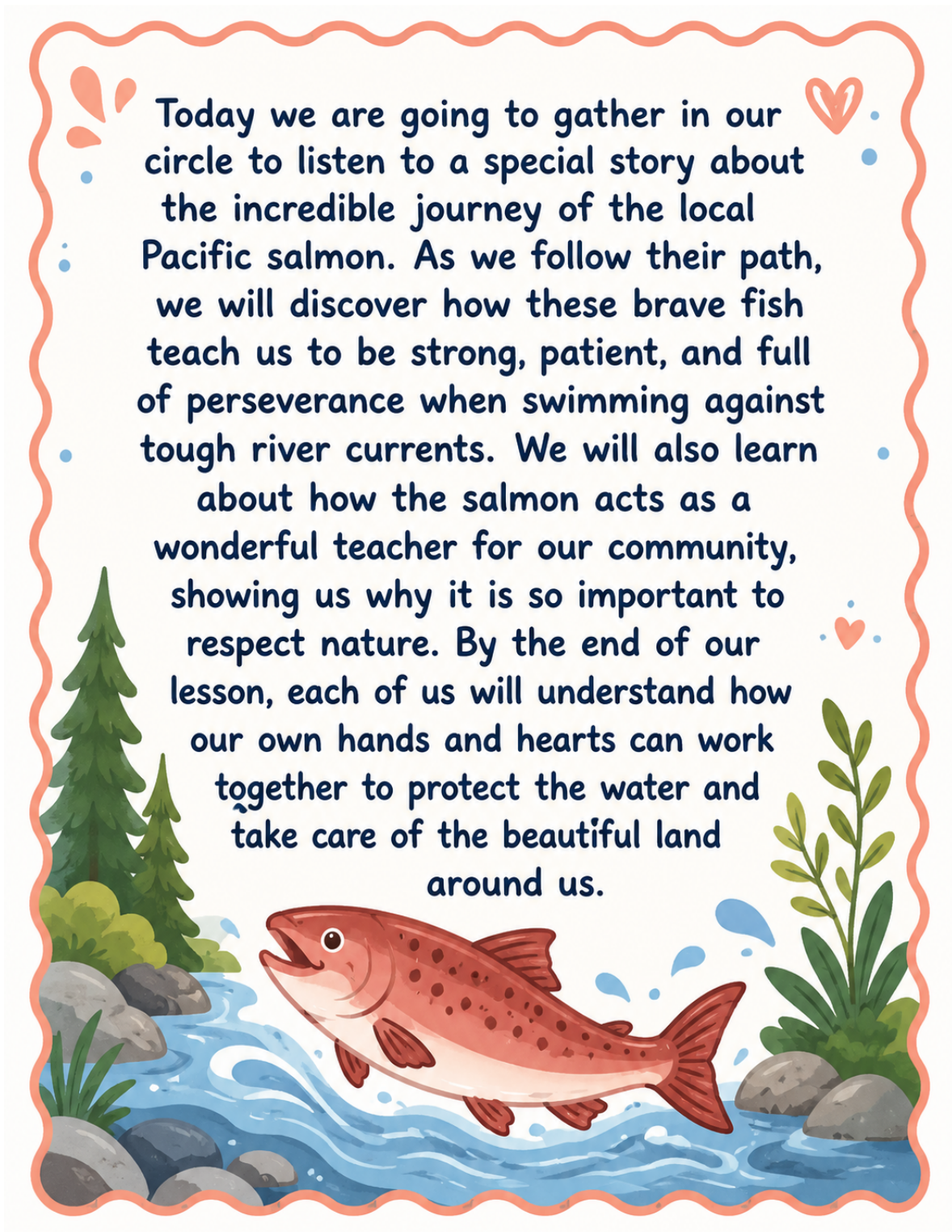


Lesson Title: The Salmon's Journey: Learning Through Story, Resilience, and Stewardship

Grade Level: 1–2



Today we are going to gather in our circle to listen to a special story about the incredible journey of the local Pacific salmon. As we follow their path, we will discover how these brave fish teach us to be strong, patient, and full of perseverance when swimming against tough river currents. We will also learn about how the salmon acts as a wonderful teacher for our community, showing us why it is so important to respect nature. By the end of our lesson, each of us will understand how our own hands and hearts can work together to protect the water and take care of the beautiful land around us.

Inquiry Question: How can we use our hands and hearts to care for the local land and the places where salmon live?

1. Foundation and Objectives

Introductory/Foundational Knowledge for Educators on Lesson Plan Subject Matter

In the Coast Salish tradition, the Pacific Salmon is not just a fish; it is a deeply respected relative and a teacher of perseverance. For generations, Indigenous communities have practiced sustainable fishing and deep stewardship of the land, showing incredible excellence in engineering (like traditional fish weirs) and ecology. Despite historical bans on cultural gatherings and traditional fishing practices (resistance), communities held onto their teachings. Today, sharing these stories and learning local words is part of bringing the culture back to life with pride (revitalization).

Intergenerational Learning with Elders and/or Knowledge Holders

Invitation to a local community Elder or Knowledge Holder (or streaming a recorded video of a local storyteller if an in-person visit isn't possible) to share a traditional story about the salmon's journey and teach us how to greet the river with respect.

BC Ministry of Education Curricular Competencies

Social Studies (Grade 1–2): Recognize connections between people and the environment; explore diverse cultural perspectives.

English Language Arts (Grade 1–2): Listen and respond to stories and oral teachings; share personal ideas and reflections.

Arts Education (Grade 1–2): Express learning through creative works using natural materials.

First Peoples Principles of Learning (FNESC)

- Learning is holistic, experiential, and relational (focused on connectedness, reciprocal relationships, and a sense of place).
- Learning is deeply embedded in text, story, and oral traditions.

Holistic Learning Outcomes

Students will:

- Listen to oral stories to understand how animals and the land support our community.
- Explore how our personal actions, hands, and hearts can care for the local environment and protect the water.
- Learn and practice a foundational word in the local Indigenous heritage language (Halq'eméylem).

Where to Find Additional Information (Resources)

- First Nations Education Steering Committee (FNESC) – *First Peoples Principles of Learning resources*.
- Local Coast Salish children's books: *Salmon Twins* by Roy Henry Vickers or stories by Nicola I. Campbell.
- BC Ministry of Education Curriculum website (Early Primary Social Studies / Arts Education).

Technology Integration

- Prior to the story circle, students will view a short, age-appropriate video clip showing the local Pacific salmon's real-life migration and habitat, bridging visual technology with oral storytelling.

2. The Four-Directions Core (Student-Centered Learning)

INTELLECTUAL – Nurturing the Mind (West)

- **Description of Activities:** * Today we are going to gather in our warm, cozy story circle on the floor to listen to a special story about the incredible journey of the local Pacific salmon.

As we follow their path, we will discover how these brave fish teach us to be strong, patient, and full of perseverance when swimming against tough river currents. We will talk about how they grow, swim, and selflessly feed the whole ecosystem.

We will engage in an open conversation about how the First Peoples have always been the caretakers of the water, standing strong to protect their relatives, the salmon.

- **Language and Culture Integration:** Introduction of a traditional story into the lesson. We will introduce a simple, beautiful word from the local heritage language (**Halq'eméylem**) that means "salmon" (*sqwá:lts / sttháqi*) or "river" (*stó:lō*), discussing how proud the community feels to keep this language alive and spoken today.
- **Materials:** An authentic Indigenous children's storybook (e.g., *Salmon Twins* by Roy Henry Vickers), a visual word-card with the local Indigenous word written clearly, and a short introductory video clip.

PHYSICAL – Activities and Experiences (North)

- **Description of Activities:** * **Relationship with The Land (Outdoor Activity):** We will take a short, mindful walk outside on the school grounds or near a local green space. The children are invited to look at the trees and plants, listen to the wind, and gently

gather fallen natural items for their artwork, thanking the earth for sharing these gifts with us.

Hands-on Creation: Students create a "*Salmon of Resilience*" art piece. They use a simple paper salmon cutout and decorate it using the natural materials they gathered from outdoors (like fallen leaves, little twigs, or small bits of moss), combining them with colorful paper scraps.

- **Materials:** Paper salmon cutouts, non-toxic glue, child-safe scissors, and the collected natural materials.

SPIRITUAL – All Our Relations (East)

- **Description of Activities:** * **Practicing Ethics in the Classroom:** Bring the decorated paper salmon back to the circle. Students practice *Care* by supporting each other while collecting materials outside and sharing art supplies, and *Respect* by listening quietly from the heart.

Stewardship Promise: Inside or on the back of their salmon (with the teacher gently helping to write it down for the younger ones), each child adds one small, heartfelt promise to help care for nature, such as "*I will not throw trash near the water*" or "*I will be kind to bugs*". This helps them see that our personal actions matter to the whole world around us.

Relationship with Family (Home Mission): Students take their artwork home to share with their family. Their "home mission" is to share the story of the brave salmon with a family member and think of one small thing they can do together at home to protect the local water or land.

EMOTIONAL – Thoughts and Feelings (South)

- **Description of Activities:** * We will close the lesson by returning to the shared Talking Circle. We will pass around a soft, natural object like a large pinecone or a smooth river stone. When a child holds the object, it is their special time to share from the heart while the rest of the classroom family practices heart-centered listening.

We will close the day by practicing our new local heritage language word together as a group.

- **Personal Reflection Time:** While holding the pinecone or stone, each child reflects on their own feelings by answering a simple, gentle question: "*How can I be strong and helpful like the salmon today?*" This lets them connect the story to their own identity, feelings, and role in the classroom family.

3. Indigenous Ways of Assessing Progress (Assessment FOR Learning)

Rather than a stressful test, assessment is woven gently through the day using a **Formative Observation Checklist** that honors Indigenous principles of holistic growth (evaluating the mind, heart, and hands):

Evaluation Domains PDF	Formative Observation Criteria PDF	Evidence of Student Growth (Grade 1–2) PDF
Heart-Centered Listening (Emotional)	Does the child listen with care, patience, and empathy during the story and circle time?	Student demonstrates respectful silence, maintains focus on the speaker, and holds the talking piece with care.
Connection to Place (Physical/Spiritual)	Does the child show a respectful, gentle attitude toward the land and the materials collected outside?	Student gathers only fallen items, expresses gratitude to the environment, and uses materials purposefully.
Reflective Expression (Intellectual/Spiritual)	Can the child share or show a simple way to care for their community and the environment?	Student formulates a simple stewardship promise and shares a reflection connecting the salmon's resilience to themselves.

4. Differentiated Instruction (Meeting Learner Differences)

To ensure this lesson is meaningfully inclusive and informed by diverse pedagogical practices, instruction is adapted for Grade 1–2 learners as follows:

- **Visual and Auditory Supports:** Use of large, clear vocabulary cards with the Halq'eméylem words alongside physical photos and short video clips of salmon migration to assist English Language Learners (ELL) and visual learners.
- **Flexible Communication / Expression:** Students can express their personal reflection orally during the Talking Circle, through artistic design on their salmon, or through dictated writing where the teacher or Educational Assistant (EA) assists in scribing their ideas.
- **Collaborative Peer Support:** Strategic partner pairing during the outdoor nature walk and the art activity to encourage cooperative learning, safety, and peer communication for students requiring social or academic scaffolding.
- **Extension Opportunities:** For students wishing to deepen their intellectual connection, additional illustrated field guides and picture books on local freshwater ecosystems will be provided in the classroom reading corner.

REFERENCES

- Campbell, N. I. (2005). *Shi-shi-etko*. Groundwood Books.
- First Nations Education Steering Committee. (2024). *First Peoples Principles of Learning*. FNEESC.
- Government of British Columbia. (2024). *BC Curriculum*. <https://curriculum.gov.bc.ca>.
- Vickers, R. H., & Budd, R. (2011). *Salmon twins*. Harbour Publishing.